



magazine

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CHILDREN OF THE PROMPT

As the *Granta* controversy amps up discussions around AI-generated fiction, publishers, writers and readers confront an uncomfortable question: how do we define authorship anymore?

FULL STORY ON
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Making of a queerly ever after

This glossy gay wedding romance charms at times but shies away from deeper realities



GETTY IMAGES

Chintan Girish Modi

If you are fed up of queer narratives populated by miserable protagonists abandoned by family, trapped in dysfunctional relationships, or facing discrimination at work, Farhad J. Dadyburjor's new novel, *Queerly Beloved*, might offer the caramel-coated escapist fantasy you have been looking for.

With the judiciary and legislature joining forces to delay legal recognition for same-sex marriage in India, there is a need for stories that sustain hope. Activism alone cannot fulfil that role; that's where fiction comes in. In *Queerly Beloved*, Mumbaikar Ved Mehra and New Yorker Carlos Silva – from Dadyburjor's last novel *The Other Man* – reunite for a glamorous Punjabi wedding.

Ved works at his father's company whereas Carlos is a travel influencer. After three years of living together, and co-parenting a dog named Fubu, they are convinced that marriage is the logical next step. Ved's mother, Dolly, is determined to make it a public spectacle and invite glitterati from all over the country. But it's impossible to have a wedding without some drama. Read the book to find out what happens when the priest backs out, the chef is unavailable, Carlos's parents cannot make it, and Ved's ex-boyfriend shows up.

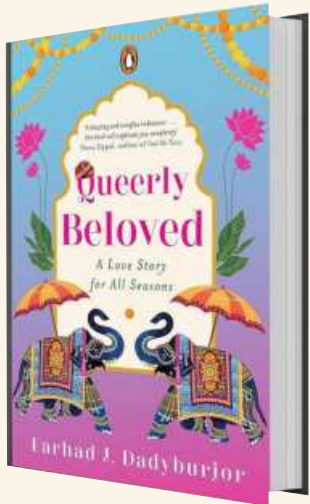
Shadab Khan's stylish cover design, with bejewelled elephants and marigold decorations, matches the mood of a storyline that delivers some feel-good moments even if it lacks the erotic charge and emotional depth of *The Other Man*, which was a finalist at the Lambda Literary Awards 2022 in the 'Gay Romance' category. What could be mistaken for blandness is, perhaps, nothing but the comfort and security the two men have found in each other after a lifetime of looking for love. They even get a second dog, Peppers, to complete their picture of a happy family.

Some tropes remain

The strongest thread in Dadyburjor's narrative is the relationship between Ved and Dolly, especially the son's struggle to accept that his divorced mother is dating a younger and physically attractive man named Raj. This is juxtaposed against the ease with which Dolly embraces Carlos's presence in her son's life.

Interestingly, Carlos is also younger than Ved, so the real issue here is not Raj's age but the fact that Ved has not paused to think about how Dolly's need for romance, companionship and sex have remained unfulfilled since her divorce.

The weakest part of the novel is Ved's characterisation as the leader of diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives at his father's company. With his plans for gender neutral bathrooms, an allowance for employees who are transitioning, and talks by leaders from the LGBTQIA+ community, he comes



Queerly Beloved
Farhad J. Dadyburjor
Penguin
₹499

across as well-meaning but we meet none of his colleagues other than Sheetal, a cisgender heterosexual woman, whose job includes planning Ved's date nights with Carlos, and disposing off 20 large bouquets of roses sent anonymously to Ved's office.

"Let's send these down to the trans shelter in Andheri – they'll be super-happy to receive them. I'll ask them to send us some pictures posing with the flowers for our Instagram account," she says. Ved's prompt approval is a bit shocking, since he worked in the NGO sector for two years, championing the rights of LGBTQIA+ people. The novel ends up reflecting, maybe unwittingly, the shallowness of corporate Pride Month initiatives that are more self-congratulatory than helpful.

The writer and literary critic's work has appeared in the anthologies *Clear Hold Build* and *Fearless Love*.

Recognising translations

A new annual award for works of fiction translated from any South Indian language

Bengaluru's Book Brahma Foundation, along with the iconic Bookworm bookstore, has instituted a literary prize aimed at promoting and recognising translated works.

The Book Brahma-Bookworm English Fiction of the Year Award will be presented to a work of fiction translated into English from any South Indian language, published between 2023 and 2025 in India or abroad. The winning author and translator will receive a combined



cash prize of ₹1,00,000 along with a plaque and a curated bouquet of books.

The shortlist will be announced on July 30, and the winner will be declared during the Book Brahma Literature Festival in Bengaluru, from August 21-23.

Interested publishers, authors and translators can submit their entries for the award at the Book Brahma Foundation's office in Bengaluru before June 30. For more details, contact chapparlike@bookbrahma.com; visit www.bookbrahmalitfest.com



(Clockwise from left) Panels from *Persepolis*; some of Marjane Satrapi's books; and the author, who died aged 56 on June 4. (GETTY IMAGES)



TRIBUTE [1969-2026]

THE COMPLICATED LEGACY OF MARJANE SATRAPI

The *Persepolis* creator's portrayal of Iran and its people may have been appropriated by the West, but there can be no doubt that her work spotlighted the lives of oppressed women

Rachita Taneja

It was the year 2008, I was hunched over the family computer with an external hard drive the size of a brick plugged in, carrying the latest haul of illegally downloaded movies my brother ferried for me from his high-speed Internet at Delhi University.

On the menu for that evening was *Persepolis* by Marjane Satrapi. I hungrily took in what felt like the first-ever complex depiction of female rage, rebellion, and audacity that my schoolgirl brain desperately needed.

Persepolis was a revelation. To say it changed my life would be an exaggeration. But it did make a home in my mind, swirling and gently whispering in my ear.

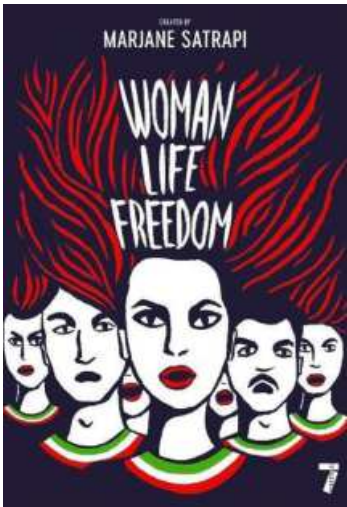
After the news of Satrapi's passing last week, my timeline was filled with reactions, critiques and tearful tributes alike. To many, she was the face of resistance against religious patriarchy, to others, she was an influential figure co-opted (perhaps, willingly) by Western imperialism.

When I first watched *Persepolis*, I lacked the media literacy and political knowledge needed to identify that the context is not always black and white. It moved me in ways that confirmed biases that most majority-religion Indians are indoctrinated into from a young age. But even then, I could identify the way in which religion, each one of them, creates arbitrary boundaries that girls and women are expected to sit quietly within. We carry the burden of honour. I could relate to the feeling of being offensive by merely existing in my body, of being morally policed, controlled, finding "freedom" only within the four walls of my home.

Whether in Iran, India or the West, women always seem to face the brunt of fascist nationalism. Everything is up for grabs – our bodies, our thoughts, our stories. Every religion seems united in the need to control girls and women, and every nationalist project is full of men eager to use our pain to advance their own agenda.

Visibility and responsibility

After Satrapi's passing on June 4, I decided to revisit *Persepolis*. Predictably, it holds up. *Persepolis* is an iconic piece of work. Released between 2000 and 2003, the autobiographical anthology has been translated into over 20 languages and holds a place in the comics section of every big bookstore here at



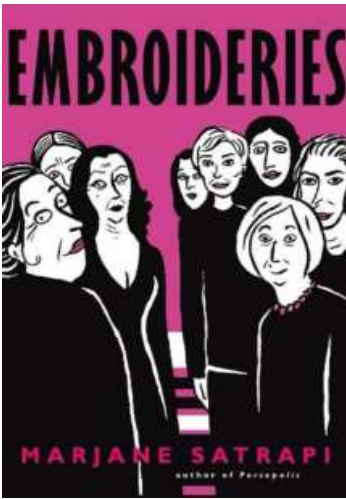
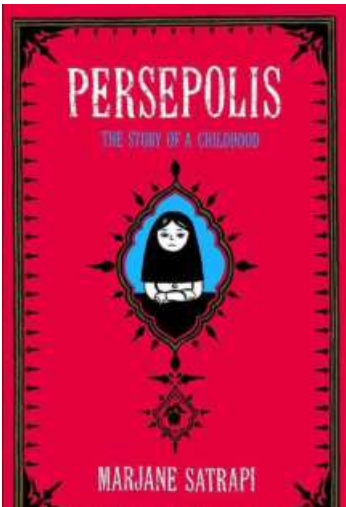
home. It is influential and persistent. Satrapi is a prolific storyteller. She has the ability to be vulnerable without shame, to point and laugh at authority (and herself) without diminishing the gravity of grief, to humanise her world. Her striking artwork influenced the landscape of graphic novels, and demonstrated the sheer power of the format.

In her work, Satrapi does more with less. As a cartoonist who works with black-and-white minimalist art, her use of negative space and bold, simple lines made me want to stop reading and start drawing. Her visual storytelling invites the reader to feel rather than be told what to feel. *Persepolis* also uses shocking and graphic imagery to great effect. The artwork is blunt and haunting – capturing exactly how a child might experience and remember violence. It is a masterclass in telling a dark story in an engaging and sometimes humorous way, without ever diminishing its cruelty.

In *Persepolis*, Satrapi tells her own story of growing up during the Islamic Revolution in Iran. Criticising her because her work has been used by Western imperialist projects to reinforce institutional Islamophobia feels like a different form of misogyny. What should she have done – not tell her story? The responsibility of situating a work within its historical and political context, and engaging with the nuance the storyteller intended, does not rest solely with the author. It is a burden that must also be shared by the audience.

Should women remain silent because there is a possibility that their accounts of resisting oppression could be appropriated by their political enemies? Absolutely not.

It is also true that the enemy of an enemy is not always a friend. After the success of *Persepolis* catapulted



Satrapi to international fame, she became a political figure. And with that visibility came a degree of responsibility. Satrapi's work was wielded by warmongers and Western imperialists to validate orientalist narratives in a post-9/11 world raring for any excuse to go to war. Her

depiction of gendered oppression under the Islamic Republic was often appropriated to further the narrative that Muslim women needed to be "saved" from their veils through Western intervention.

Making room for complexity

Satrapi did not have the power to control how her autobiographical work was deployed by others, but she did have the power, and the platform, to reinforce the anti-imperialist stance she claimed to hold. And in many ways, she did exactly that. She spoke out against Western intervention, criticised France's ban on the hijab, and defended Iran when her work was used to demonise Iranians rather than accomplish what she had originally set out to do: portray them as full human beings and bring their stories closer to the rest of the world.

However, it could be patronising to Satrapi to suggest that she was merely a passive observer of how her work was interpreted, given all that has transpired since *Persepolis* was first published in 2000. Therein lies my disappointment. In recent years, Satrapi increasingly echoed neoliberal talking points and, at times, rhetoric that veered uncomfortably close to the political right. This was especially apparent following the escalation of Israel's violence against Palestinians after October

7, 2023, when some of her public interventions seemed at odds with the anti-imperialist commitments she had previously articulated.

Satrapi was a complex person whose life was shaped by grief and trauma. In an era where judgments are formed and verdicts delivered within a single news cycle, I want to make room for complexity. I resist the urge to define her solely by the positions I found most troubling, or by her most recent public remarks.

She became an international figure because of the power and beauty of her storytelling in *Persepolis*. Through that work, she touched my life, offering insights that deepened my curiosity and expanded my empathy. For that, I am grateful.

The writer is an award-winning political cartoonist and the creator of webcomic *Sanitary Panels*. Her debut book, *Touching Grass*, is out now.



Manil Suri's book emerges from the 2,711 letters he exchanged with his mother over three decades. (LARRY COLE)

Saurabh Sharma

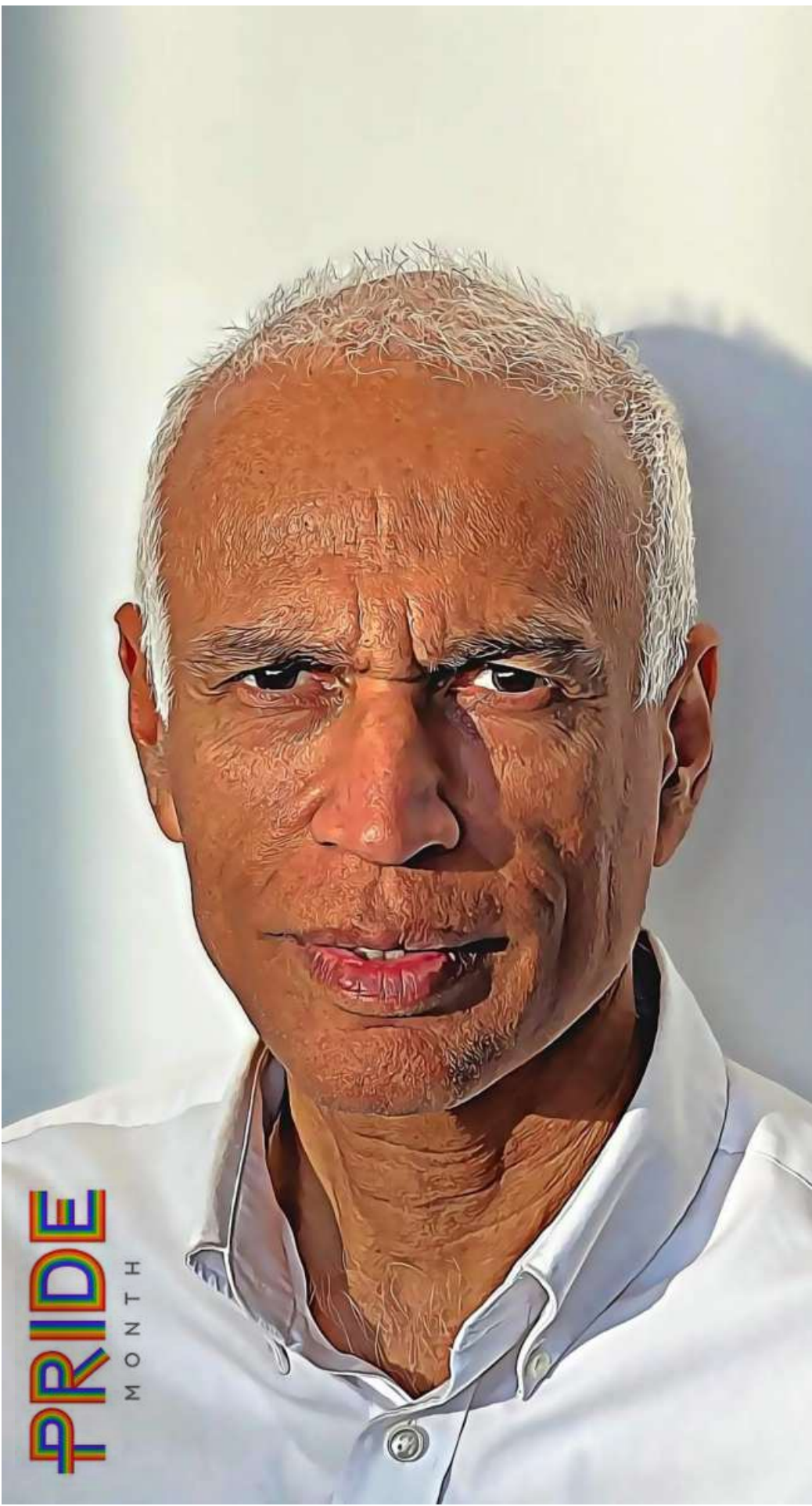
While he has demonstrated creating numbers out of nothing (an empty set), for *A Room in Bombay: A Memoir* (HarperCollins India), novelist and mathematics professor, Manil Suri, did have a concrete set: the 2,711 letters he exchanged with his mother between 1979, the time he moved to the U.S., and 2010, shortly before her “psychiatric hospitalisation”. “Someday, maybe you will write a book about them,” his mother had said to him.

“It had seemed more like a responsibility than an opportunity,” Suri notes in the book. His mother, Prem, was able to read the first chapter before her condition deteriorated. “She was still halfway lucid,” Suri says during an interview over email.

The book's overriding theme is entrapment, symbolised by the room in Bombay's Razia Mansion where Suri's parents moved after living separately for 11 years. When Suri was born in 1959, he became the centre of their universe.

The hold the room had
At 20, Suri decided to leave for the U.S. “Of course, you can't keep living here,” Prem had said when Suri expressed an interest in pursuing further studies. She was at the airport, determined not to miss even the “last glimpse” of her son's Pittsburgh-bound plane.

Yet the room, and the hold it continued to exert over his parents, kept drawing him back to Bombay. Reflecting on moving away but never truly escaping either the room or his family, Suri says, “Whether one is talking about a room or marriage or a closet, each of these can either be a prison or a refuge – or both. One can feel trapped and confined within it, but one can also find reassurance and safety within



its familiar boundaries.”

Prem decided to stay at Razia Mansion despite the harassment she and her family faced there, amid attempts by neighbours to take over the flat given rising real estate prices. According to Suri, this was because his mother was deeply attached to “South Bombay, in the lively, bustling, constantly stimulating Kemps Corner area”. He says more than the room, it was the locality she really didn't want to let go of.

“It wasn't just her, but several of the other people in the flat as well, who felt the

Besides the familial dynamics, the memoir offers only limited glimpses of Bombay in the 1970s, when Section 377 of the erstwhile Indian Penal Code, criminalising consensual same-sex relations, prevailed

same way,” he says. “She was also determined to get any money that was coming to her in return for relinquishing her rights to the room. Rather than a sense of failure, I think she would have been overcome with wistfulness and nostalgia if forced to let go.”

The balancing act
The estranged couple doted on their only child, but had little affection for each other. “By trusting so much to my judgment, they engendered in me a sense of responsibility, rather than turning me into a

INTERVIEW

‘A ROOM CAN BE A PRISON OR A REFUGE, OR BOTH’

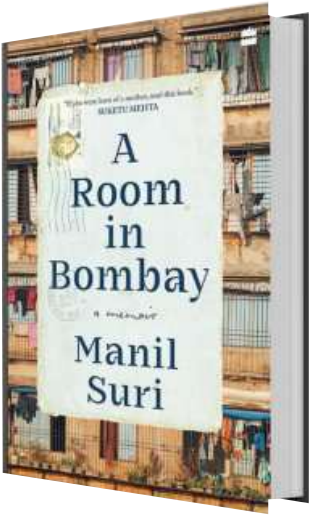
Mathematician and writer Manil Suri on growing up in a Bombay room with estranged parents, and a childhood enclosed by love and constrained sexuality

spoiled monstrosity,” Suri writes in the book.

But did that burden ever become overwhelming? Suri admits that it did. He says he was still a child, and that this formed part of his moulding – a formative experience that shaped his personality.

Between the two, it was Prem who asserted her love for him strongly. Did that colour his judgment regarding his father? “Indeed, my mother influenced how I viewed my father,” he says. “There is a section in the book which describes the time he came to visit me in the U.S. without Prem, and I was able to see my father for who he was, without refraction through the prism of my mother's resentments.” But it was a balancing act – I tried to be as fair as I could to both my parents, and keep them both happy as much as possible. My mother was conscious about this as well, and tried her best not to consciously undermine the relationship I had with my father.”

World beyond the room
Besides the familial dynamics, the memoir offers only limited glimpses of Bombay in the 1970s, when Section 377 of the erstwhile Indian Penal Code, criminalising consensual



same-sex relations, prevailed. Given the risk of extortion – where queer people could be threatened with being outed unless they paid up – how did people forge romantic connections? Suri notes that the idea of extortion or harassment never entered his mind. “My friends weren't worried, either. Sadly, the people who were in danger were invariably from the less well-off strata of society,” he explains.

In the age of dating apps and instant hook-ups, what many queer people increasingly share today is a sense that building steady partnerships has become more difficult. Suri feels it has

“become harder to find a monogamous partner” for people like his younger gay friend, who “lamented” that “with sex so readily procurable, it's become very difficult to find a partner interested in building life together”.

For Suri, things did fall into place in that regard. He has been in a 36-year-long monogamous relationship with his partner, Larry. He says, there were a few rough patches, which the couple got over with, thanks to “copious amounts of black humour.”

Thinking of the time when he needed medical support for his mother, Suri says mental healthcare in India has always been given less attention than it deserves. Though 16 years have passed since he negotiated with the Indian healthcare system, he can't forget the “shock over learning that there were only two hospitals with psychiatric wards for the whole of Bombay”. The only “lifesaver” was the Dignity Foundation. The real trap, in a sense, is systemic; it was the case then and remains so now.

The interviewer is a Delhi-based queer writer and culture critic.

Cooking up a legacy

In his memoir, filled with recipes, anecdotes, and glimpses of family life, Rahul Akerkar looks back on helping build India's modern restaurant culture

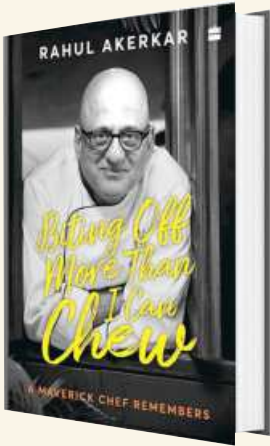
Sumana Mukherjee

It is hard today to imagine urban India without its restaurants. Sometime in the past couple of decades, standalone restaurants, including coffee shops, nudged aside living rooms, parks, cultural centres, and street corners to become the theatre for connections. From casual catch-ups to lunchtime business meetings, impress-the-date evenings to meet-the-parents teas, ideating start-ups to celebrating successes, restaurants are now the default setting for much of *desi* human drama. And if there is one person who can be credited for birthing the upmarket standalone phenomenon, it must be Rahul Akerkar, who set up Indigo in Mumbai in 1999.

Lest you think that is an overstatement, here is the caveat. Part of Akerkar's secret is, of course, being at the right place at the right time. But part of it is also his lineage: a privileged, prodigiously talented South Bombay kid who could chuck a career in the sciences after an Ivy League education with his parents' blessings, and start a catering business from their kitchen. But

much of it, as is clear from this must-read memoir, has to do with his intrinsic honesty about himself, his food, his team, his relationships and, most importantly, his mistakes.

A ringside view
Akerkar warns early that *Biting Off More Than I Can Chew* can function as a morality tale for all those creatives who think themselves as



Biting Off More Than I Can Chew: A Maverick Chef Remembers
Rahul Akerkar
HarperCollins India
₹1,199

entrepreneurs with a great idea and an eagerness to learn the business on the job, and often find themselves out of depth. But for any observer of India's restaurant industry and its people, this exhilarating memoir works as a ringside view for one of the most dynamic sectors of the Indian economy.

Akerkar opens his memoir where most interest in food begins: in granny's kitchen. Born of a Konkani Hindu father and a German Jewish mother, Akerkar was able to grasp his unlikely heritage with both hands, straddling New York City (where his mother's parents lived) and Nashik (home to his paternal grandparents) with equanimity. As a child shipped off for holidays to the U.S., he experienced his Jewish grandmother's kitchen with the same curiosity and freedom as he had felt in Nashik. And it all came together when, while studying in Pennsylvania, he began working as a server at a French bistro.

A gifted (if egoistic!) raconteur who wields the pen with as much fluidity and grace as he does the



knife, Akerkar writes the ‘becoming’ part of his story with wit and self-awareness. But it is when he returns to Bombay that the narrative takes off in full chaos and glory.

His take on the eating-out scene in pre-liberalisation India is spot on: “At the high-end, there were only restaurants in five-star hotels”, where exclusivity was wrapped up in snobbery, “the mom-and-pop restaurants, mostly serving Indian food”, where cooks were “menial labour”, and the chain restaurants, exemplified by United Coffee House and Copper Chimney, and the Chinese restaurant, serving a “Sino-Punjabi amalgam”.

What was missing, Akerkar realised, was “the kind of

cosmopolitan café scene I might want to hang out at myself” – and the rest, one might say, is history. Except it wasn't – because, before Indigo, there was A Moveable Feast, the caterers; Just Desserts, the sweets bar that breathed life into Bombay's business district after dark; Under the Over, named in Time magazine's Best of Asia list in 1992; Kuteeram, Protima Bedi's dance gurukul on the outskirts of Bangalore; and then a near-move to the U.S., before which his wife and business partner Malini discovered the perfect tumbledown colonial structure behind the Taj Mahal Palace Hotel for what would go on to become the iconic Indigo.

Making an eatery work
There is life after Indigo too, but what is delightful is Akerkar's insightful recalibration of the components that make a restaurant work. From service, décor and music, to the development of an intelligent, unorthodox cuisine that combines indigenous and foreign ingredients and cooking methods, and supports wine-pairing, his ideas have a long legacy. Also critical is the way he professionalised his restaurants and set the standards for those who would come next.

However, *Biting...* lacks context for the restaurant boom: it was fed directly by the economic liberalisation policies, which opened doors, put money into people's wallets, and changed the way India ate and drank. I would have also loved to know more about the chef's pivot into Awadhi food after a primary relationship with European and American cuisines. That apart, the memoir – beautifully produced and illustrated, peppered with outstanding recipes, and leavened with outrageous anecdotes and warm glimpses of family life – can be likened to the best of Akerkar's food: big, hearty, full of flavour and subtlety, and so very more-ish.

The reviewer is a writer and editor based in Bengaluru.

TRICKTIONARY EPISODE 32

WHY DIDN'T YOU LET ME READ?

Revisiting the trauma inflicted by the parents of children in the 1980s and 90s

Dear readers, let me tell you a true story. When I was six or seven, there was a small fire in our neighbour's flat. It was not at all a serious fire. And, in fact, the fire was put out through the efforts of all the residents on that floor. We all took buckets full of water and doused the flames in half an hour or so. I have no memory of this family now. But I remember they were very nice and had two children. And they were actually in the the process of packing up their belongings and shifting to another flat when the accident took place. Later that evening, they came to my house and asked for me. "Young man," they said, "we wish to reward you for your valiant efforts with the buckets. You may come to our house and take as many books as you like." As far as I can remember, I was not a voracious reader at this point. I

read a bit. But not excessively so. And then I went to their house and picked up a stack of slightly charred books. And this changed my life. Because I became a reader. And also, perhaps even more severely, I became a procurer of books. My parents were relieved. Okay look, they said, Sidin is not only well-behaved and handsome but also a bookworm. Praise the lord. He has heard our prayers. And then what did they say right afterwards? "Sidin, please put that book down. Don't read when other people are there. It is very bad manners." Dear readers who were parents of small children in the 1980s and '90s, why were you people like this? Why did you torture us book-readers? Do you think we want to sit with 35 other family members and hear about coconut plantations, inflation or P.V. Narasimha Rao? No. We just want to help Nancy Drew overcome



neighbourhood criminality. Fine. I know what you guys are saying. You are saying: Sidin, this happened in the past. Perhaps, it is time to bury old grudges. No. No. A thousand times no. And I will tell you why. Because of a new scourge that is

Screeniority /skri:n'ɔrti/ noun **Definition:** The hypocritical practice whereby elders who once forbade younger family members from reading books or magazines in company now demand unrestricted access to their phones, reels, and viral videos at all social gatherings, regardless of occasion. **Related forms:** **Screenior** (noun): An elder who practises screeniority **Screeniorise** (verb): To demand phone privileges while denying others the right to read **Screenioritis** (noun): The chronic condition of believing one's own screen time is acceptable while others' reading is antisocial

Make no mistake readers, I am completely in favour of people consuming any and all content at all times. Except Formula One racing. What is this F1 nonsense? Nothing more than competitive traffic. No. My issue is with the same people, who castigated me for having the audacity to pick up books in the company of others, now sitting and watching YouTube during family get-togethers. I was not allowed to partake of James Joyce, Franz Kafka, Jane Austen or *Hardy Boys*. But you can watch random people doing an incompetent group dance in front of waterfalls? This is absolute and total shenanigans. And what is worse, they will still not allow me to pick up a book or a magazine. Oh look, they will say, this fellow has not changed

his antisocial tendencies since he was 10 years old. And then suddenly, from one corner, Instagram reels will start playing. Friends, I am tired of this duplicitous behaviour. However, I am scared of shouting at my elderly relatives. So, I would be obliged if you could somehow convince them? All over the world, governments have started banning social media for children. I think, perhaps, they have this the wrong way around. Perhaps, we should ban it for people above the age of 65. And also for people below the age of 20. People between the ages of 20 and 65 may be allowed. But before we campaign for this legislation, I think we must first come up with a word to capture this skullduggery. Where the same elders who prevented us from reading in public places now demand that they have instantaneous access to news and viral videos in every circumstance, including at weddings, funerals, birthday parties, housewarming parties, etc. And that word is: screeniority. **Example sentence:** "At his niece's wedding, Piyush uncle exercised full screeniority by watching the entirety of *Sholay* without any headphones." Have you witnessed screeniority in your household? Did you admonish your elders for this duplicity? Did you do this without getting removed from last wills and testaments? Please tell me how immediately, via email.



Sidin Vadukut helps early stage companies communicate better. He blogs at www.whatay.com

Bob Jones

Today's deal is from a recent tournament in Australia. South's slightly off-shape opening bid hid his diamond suit, so West reasonably led a diamond. South had eight top tricks. The contract was safe if East held the ace of hearts, plus there was a good chance West would duck his ace of hearts if he had

GOREN BRIDGE

Choices

East-West vulnerable, South deals

it. To be as deceptive as possible, South won the opening diamond lead in his hand and led the seven of hearts away from his king. West knew from the bidding that South only had two hearts and saw no reason to duck his ace. West rose with his ace of hearts and shifted smartly to the queen of clubs! The defense

NORTH				EAST	
♠	Q 5	♥	Q 9 8 6 5	♠	J 9 8 7 2
♦	A 10 8	♦	A 10 8	♥	10 4 3 2
♣	K 8 5	♣	K 8 5	♦	Void
WEST				SOUTH	
♠	10 6	♠	A K 4 3	♥	K 7
♥	A J	♥	K 7	♦	K Q J 5 2
♦	9 7 6 4 3	♦	K Q J 5 2	♣	4 3
♣	Q 10 7 6	♣	4 3		

The bidding: SOUTH WEST NORTH EAST 1NT Pass 2♣* 2♥ Pass 3NT All pass *Transfer to hearts

Opening lead: Seven of ♦

took four club tricks to defeat the contract. South might have tried the effect of running his long suit. This will sometimes create problems for the defense. On this deal, East would have to find five discards. He could only part with one spade, and a club discard would mean the

defense could only take three club tricks provided declarer did not release dummy's king of clubs. Best defense would be to discard all four of his hearts. South would have to read the position, of course, but he could now prevail by playing four rounds of spades leaving East on lead with only clubs remaining. Dummy's king of clubs would become declarer's ninth trick.

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

All you need to know about blood



While some animals have transparent blood, spiders, lobsters and octopuses have blue blood. (GETTY IMAGES)

Berty Ashley

1 Born on June 14, 1868, Karl Landsteiner was a biologist who, along with Alexander Wiener, identified the Rhesus (Rh) factor in blood. This discovery made blood transfusions significantly safer. Landsteiner's earlier work also led to the classification system that most of us are familiar with today. What is it? 2 Culturally, we associate the colour red with blood. However, some animals have transparent blood, while spiders, lobsters and octopuses have blue blood due to the presence of the oxygen-carrying protein

haemocyanin. If iron gives human blood its red colour, which metal is responsible for the blue colour of haemocyanin? 3 In this country, it is traditionally believed that blood type can indicate a person's personality and temperament. People often mention their blood type when introducing themselves, and novelty products themed around blood groups are common. Known as *ketsueki-gata*, in which country is this belief widespread? 4 Research has shown that these little creatures are more attracted to people with blood type O than to those with other blood groups. Although

they do not taste blood before biting, they are attracted to chemical signals released through the skin and sweat. What creatures are these? 5 Human blood contains trace amounts of many elements, including around 0.2 mg of this precious metal. Since it is highly unreactive, it has no known biological function. What is this element that might make you feel a little more valuable? 6 Blood group AB is the rarest of the major ABO blood types. It is characterised by the presence of both A and B antigens on red blood cells (RBCs) and the absence of anti-A and anti-B antibodies in the plasma. What

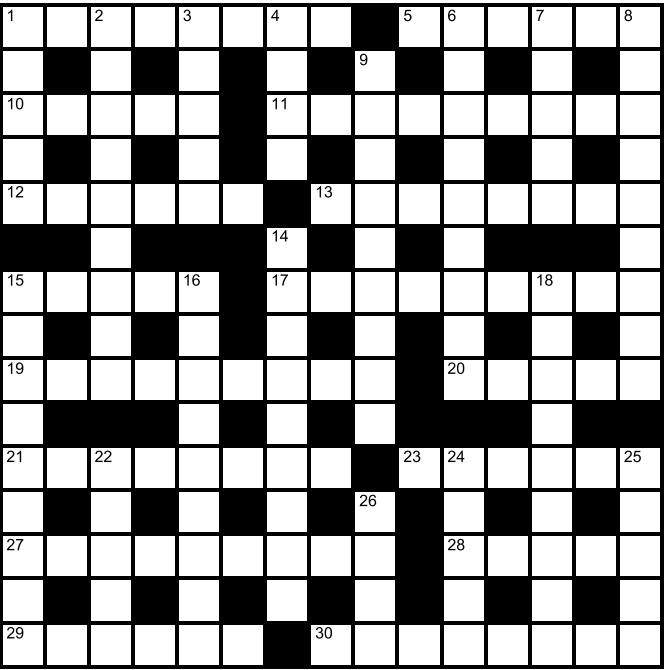
special distinction does this give people with AB blood? 7 This vehicle is equipped with a specially installed refrigerator that carries a supply of life-saving blood for emergency transfusions. The blood is always of one specific type and belongs to the person travelling inside. If the vehicle is known as 'The Beast', whose blood type does it carry? 8 The human body produces around two million RBCs every second to replace those that are constantly being lost. This process, known as erythropoiesis, takes place primarily in which part of the body? 9 This major component of blood can help patients suffering from severe burns. Although it is about 90-92% water, it contains proteins such as albumin that help maintain blood volume and prevent shock. What component of blood is this? 10 RBCs are highly specialised for transporting oxygen. To maximise the space available for haemoglobin, they lack a structure found in almost every other human cell. What is absent from mature red blood cells?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

- 1. ABO blood group system
- 2. Copper
- 3. Japan
- 4. Mosquitoes
- 5. Gold
- 6. They are universal recipients
- 7. The U.S.'s President's
- 8. Bone marrow
- 9. Plasma
- 10. A nucleus

Answers

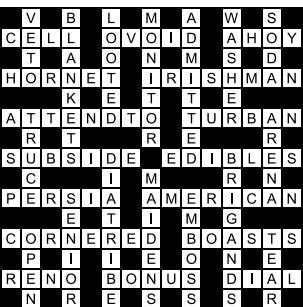
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 60 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
- 1 Son going back to hug female near stream gets plain vanilla, perhaps (2-6)
 - 5 Adult movies edited in absence of European author (6)
 - 10 Fight for a piece (5)
 - 11 Showed the ibex running around one near end of field (9)
 - 12 Insect was returning next to zipper (6)
 - 13 Malicious elf is put adrift (8)
 - 15 Impromptu commencement of dance in Bali is funny (2-3)
 - 17 Silly to cover mummy... It's not literal! (9)
 - 19 Will try a setter by the book (9)
 - 20 Weight, perhaps, of article in vehicle (5)
 - 21 Cocks rifle at first, placing on damaged rests after a couple of rounds (8)
 - 23 Remaining ones having troubled rest around hospital behind job centre (6)
 - 27 Place to keep papers from short court proceeding (9)
 - 28 Bird starting to die in rush (5)
 - 29 Signs up travelling salespersons without passes (6)
 - 30 Tape container that may be obtained from test case (8)

- 4 Fibbed, "There's a note in the cover" (4)
- 6 Excitedly I combust a quark-like particle, for example (9)
- 7 Wrongly omit female's dominant theme (5)
- 8 Cite devil wrongly, to wit (9)
- 9 Without it, pilot shifts awkwardly and takes without paying (9)
- 14 Plumber's unachievable vision (4,5)
- 15 American-Indian actor is at Elba resort and can be changed (9)
- 16 Pretty futile arrangement by boy to collect gold (9)
- 18 Happened to be evicted (6,3)
- 22 Shaped Rosie's willow (5)
- 24 Check Mark's parasites (5)
- 25 Grass-like plant contained in processed gels (5)
- 26 Letter from Druze tablet (4)

SOLUTION NO. 59



The road teaches
what war cannot

Advitya Madan
advityanidhi14@gmail.com

Reading about conflict in Lebanon often takes me back to 2006, when I commanded 15 Punjab as part of the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL). Those were demanding days, managing frequent violations along the Blue Line between Hezbollah and Israeli forces. The task required neutrality, restraint and professionalism.

Yet, the most enduring lesson from that tenure did not come from conflict management, but from something far more ordinary – the act of driving.

Soon after arrival, all ranks were required to qualify for a UN driving licence at the UNIFIL headquarters in Naqoura. Confident of our men's abilities, I assumed this would be routine. I was mistaken. From the first batch, only two passed. The rest returned visibly crestfallen.

The reason became clear on inquiry. The test in Lebanon was exacting. Conducted on a structured course with signals, slopes and tight turns, it required meticulous pre-drive checks, strict lane discipline, correct use of mirrors and indicators, and precise handling of situations such as hill starts and parking. Even minor errors led to failure. The test lasted nearly an hour, and most of us – including me – needed multiple attempts to pass.

Back home in India, driving tests are typically brief, conducted on simple tracks, and allow for a fair margin of error. The emphasis is on basic control rather than disciplined road behaviour. Passing is common; rigour is not.

But the deeper lesson lay beyond the test. It was visible on Lebanese roads, in the conduct of ordinary citizens. In a country recovering from war, I saw drivers display remarkable courtesy. Vehicles stopped well before pedestrian crossings, even if the pedestrian was only approaching. Drivers yielded space without hesitation. There was little honking, no aggression to get ahead, and a quiet respect for shared road space.

I found myself gradually adopting these habits. Today, back in my hometown of Patiala, I practise the same courtesies – offering way at intersections, acknowledging others with a simple gesture, avoiding unnecessary honking, and maintaining lane discipline.

The contrast is striking. If a war-affected nation like Lebanon can demonstrate such refined driving etiquette, what prevents us from doing the same?

The answer lies not in infrastructure, but in attitude.

Driving, like soldiering, demands discipline, awareness and respect for others.



Pallavi Goswami
jhulas@gmail.com

In all aspects of life, change remains a constant. Change is as perennial as time. The two almost go hand in hand.

To begin with, our age and its interconnectedness with time. We are born and we die. In between, we live. But in this part we call life, we change in all manners, physical change being the most visible and notable. Often one wonders why do we need to change past our youth? Why can't we always remain in the prime of life and look the same till it is time to part ways with the world.

The decay and degeneration of the human body and at times, the mind, is it necessary? To look beautiful in our ripe old age and have the same energy and vigour is not too much to ask for. It's a wish nobody will deny, if granted.

The wish that leads us to choose ways which promise to give an appearance of agelessness. Hark! There is a whole industry built around this wish. The beauty industry. And why not?

Attractiveness and appeal

Cosmetics and personal-care products vouch for attractiveness and appeal. They also claim to boost self-confidence and overall well-being. With these alluring incentives, who wouldn't want to pay? But underneath the glossy products, lurks the potential dangers and risks that come with some of these products. Hence the term "toxic beauty".

Beauty that comes with a price indeed but a very heavy price when associated with health hazards. The chemical substances used can have a very damaging effect on the health of individuals even when these products are used topically. Little do we know when we apply or take in some of the so-called beauty and personal-care products.

External beauty is sought after. Men and women alike feel the need to look attractive and appealing. While women have a bigger market for these products, an increasing

THE DEMANDS
OF BEAUTY

Underneath glossy
products lurk potential
dangers and risks

number of men have embraced cosmetics and self-care products. The idea of masculinity has changed over the years and so has the industry which now churns out beard-care products, anti-age formulations, and hair and skin-care items readily available on the shelves.

Self-esteem

Women, especially, dread to flaunt their grey strands. What if a few peeps out? It can create quite a flutter amid a roomful of coloured, glossy heads.

Does grey hair reduce self-esteem? Does it make one seem sloppy, unsophisticated, inefficient, gloomy and all the negatives that one can think of? Then again, did our grannies know of manicure and pedicure? Yet, they had beautiful hands which held us and fed us. Beautiful feet which helped them accomplish a hundred chores in and around the house. We love them not for their outer beauty but their inner strength. That reminds me of nail art. And I wonder again; how do fashionable nails enhance beauty? Men are keeping pace with women in

embracing grooming rituals. Such is the state of affairs that all the services which were traditionally offered to women are now in high demand among men. The grooming market for men has seen a significant rise driven by the shift from traditional masculinity. Companies have launched a plethora of products to satisfy the desire of their male consumers to look and feel good. Hairstyles giving that immaculate look coupled with a well-trimmed beard and moustache, waxed arms and chest, giving that immaculate look. Oh! How dapper he looks!

Grooming standards are followed by the young and old across genders. And who can be blamed? It has, in recent years, become an integral part of modern culture. Hence, college and university students come not only with their notebooks and textbooks but also with their style statements to the classroom. One is forced to note their well-groomed appearance which is not limited to their clothes. For the youth, appearance has become a mode of communication. It has given them a language to express themselves in their endeavour to create their self-identity.

They are indeed "powerful consumers" for the cosmetics industry which thrives on numbers. For someone who is a silent observer, I must say I miss the innocence in their look, the child-like nature which is so endearing, and the carefree attitude. Now it is a fixation on looks at a young age and an exposure to beauty products that emphasise the importance of appearance over other values and qualities. The future is going to be quite different and unimaginable if this is the "trend" or rather the "latest trend". I shudder and rest my pen at this thought.



While women have a bigger market for these products, an increasing number of men have embraced cosmetics and self-care products. Such is the state of affairs that all beauty services which were traditionally offered to women are now in high demand among men

Failing the test

It's hard to find a person who
genuinely believes that a
woman needs period leave



ISTOCK/ GETTY IMAGES

take me there.

At 8.20 a.m., a young trainee doctor rushed into the room with an anxious, almost wild look in his eyes. "I'm sorry, but we'll have to reschedule your surgery for tomorrow."

I couldn't believe it.

Keeping my voice steady, I asked, "Is there something wrong? Was something missed



The sneaking suspicion was spot on. The understanding and sympathetic person who genuinely believes a woman is entitled to period leave just does not exist

during my pre-anaesthetic check-up?"

He shifted uncomfortably and mumbled, "No, no, everything is perfectly fine."

I felt a little dizzy thinking of all the arrangements that had been made just for this day. As my daughter-in-law rushed out to the balcony – where the signal was better – to call home and try to rearrange everything, I continued questioning the young doctor. "Why was it postponed?"

He was sweating profusely now. "Madam is on leave today."

"Oh! What happened?"

"She called in this morning and said she was taking her period leave."

I smiled understandingly. "Oh, how wonderful that lady doctors get such benefits. I could never do so in my heyday."

My smile seemed to make the young trainee nervous. He looked at me suspiciously. "Are you not angry?"

"No. But why do you ask?"

He frowned and stared at his feet. "The last time we had to postpone a case, the patient became so angry that she threatened to burn down the East Wing of the hospital. And the patient before that swore to drag us to court for hiring lady doctors when we knew such allowances had to

be made."

I shook my head with a clucking noise. "How can people be so insensitive?"

He continued looking at me strangely. "In fact, no patient has ever been as understanding as you are about a last-minute postponement of surgery due to period leave."

I waved a hand generously.

He continued. "...so much so... that we feel you may be too good to be true."

I raised an eyebrow and smiled. "So tell me, young man, how do I prove that I am for real?"

He hesitated before replying. "There is only one proven way."

Now I was curious. "And what is that?" His eyes shifted toward the mirror near the washbasin. "It's a time-tested method. If your reflection appears in the mirror, you are real. Otherwise, you're not." Being a 1990s movie buff myself, I was well aware of this trick, so I obliged by stepping beside my bed in full view of the mirror. We both stared at the reflection. His sneaking suspicion was spot on. The understanding and sympathetic person who genuinely believes a woman is entitled to period leave doesn't exist. For, in the reflection, there was only one of us.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The article rightly highlights how shade and green spaces remain concentrated in affluent neighbourhoods. ('No place to rest'; June 7) Urban planning requires balancing development with accessibility. Local authorities must mandate green corridors in new projects and ensure maintenance of existing parks accessible to all citizens equally.

M. Barathi

The situation is far worse for gig workers and other marginalised groups who spend long hours on the road with little access to rest facilities. Unfortunately, many people fail to recognise how serious this issue is. This article has brought attention to an often-overlooked concern affecting millions.

S. Sundareswara Pandiyan

A cherished writer

The connection that Ruskin Bond shares with his readers is simply amazing. ('Being Ruskin Bond'; June 7) His collection of stories and novels have a special place due to their simplicity of narrative aiding in reading for pleasure, especially among children.

Rashmi Guru Pradeep

Iron will

Indira Jaising's contribution to the legislation on domestic violence has brought relief to countless women. ('Now is the time to reclaim the Constitution'; June 7) She is an inspiration for youngsters, especially young women, to model themselves as lawyers with ethical values and integrity.



MORE ON THE WEB
www.thehindu.com/opinion/open-page

Tourism, an experience or trauma

The States must come forward to regulate tourism, giving utmost importance to the safety of people

Ashok Balakrishna

The House of Sigmund Freud

Located at Wien IX, Berggasse 19 in Vienna, the apartment is widely regarded as the birthplace of psychoanalysis

Sonia Singla

Gold and glitter

Gold is just a shiny metal that has value only because people agree to pretend it does

Thomas Paul

Rain and shine

The transition from summer to monsoon isn't just a season change, it's nature hitting the refresh button

Ambili Aravind

Kosaraju Chandramouli

Revolutionary figure

To read about the revolutionary zeal and dedication of Mallu Swarajyam was indeed inspiring. ('Born into privilege, lived in revolt'; June 7) That she was instrumental in fighting the Zamindari system tooth and nail and redistributing wealth among the have-nots was only one part of the unwavering motto of her life.

Ayyasseri Raveendranath

Fun read

For satire and sarcasm lovers like me, this article was real fun to read. ('Group dance in Hormuz'; June 7) The irony was brought out very well. Thanks for this refreshing 'cool' surprise in this hot weather.

K. Vijayalakshmi

Community service

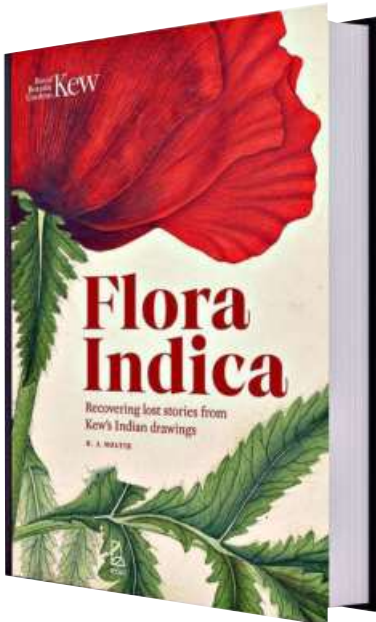
Raja Muzaffar Bhat's work through RTI and NGT shows what citizens can achieve. ('Raja Muzaffar Bhat: grassroots man'; June 7) The government must establish firm timelines and penalties for non-compliance to make accountability meaningful and ensure lasting environmental protection for vulnerable communities.

S.M. Jeeva

Late to fame

Ramya Reddy's work documenting Toda embroidery deserves recognition. ('The Toda edit in Mumbai'; June 7) These weavers create exquisite work yet receive minimal compensation. Museums and collectors should purchase directly from artisans rather than through intermediaries.

Abbharna Barathi



(Clockwise from above) The *Flora Indica* book; Sikkim cucumber; botanist Henry Noltie; cobra lily; Chinese fan palm; and Iranian poppy. (COURTESY ROLI BOOKS)

Nidhi Gupta

Deep in the Kew Gardens archive some years ago, Henry Noltie found a drawing that had been cut in half. It was a large watercolour of a *salak* palm (*Salacca zalacca*). He didn't think he'd ever find the other half, but months later, it turned up mounted on a herbarium sheet in a specimen cupboard, where it lay unidentified. More indifference than inefficiency – for what could be the value of anonymous “company-style” paintings of plants from the Indian subcontinent from 200 years ago?

A lot for someone like Noltie, who is pleased that some “wonderful paper conservators have been able to rejoin Humpty Dumpty”, as he refers to the two halves. Days before the launch of his book *Flora Indica: Recovering Lost Stories from Kew's Indian Drawings* (Roli Books, ₹2,495) in Delhi, he remembers the last few years that he has (in the words of William Dalrymple, who has written the foreword) “spent sleuthing in the dusty, dark cupboards” of the Royal Botanic Gardens at Kew.

Finding and restoring that drawing – and hundreds, if not thousands, like it – has consumed the renowned Scottish botanist and taxonomist in his later career. Now a research associate at the Royal Botanic Garden Edinburgh (RBGE), Noltie's detective work began in the early 2010s, when he became aware of and sorted through a vast collection of Indian drawings there: about a quarter of a million of them.

That led him to a similar project at Kew. Sifting through

7,500 drawings brought him and his co-curator, Hyderabad-based researcher Sita Reddy, to about 50 that were showcased as part of the exhibition *Flora Indica*, at Kew's Shirley Sherwood Gallery until April before coming to India (later this year). Although that is not nearly enough, if you ask him.

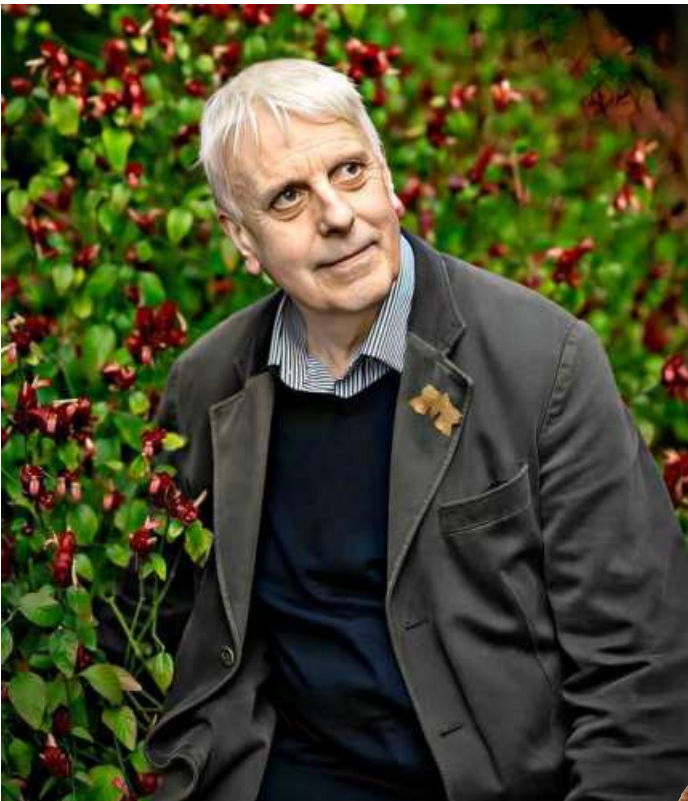
“One of [the purposes of this book was to raise] appreciation of the skill of the artists,” says Noltie over a Zoom call, adding that they were able to include 100 illustrations in the book. “Botanical illustration in India did go into a decline over the last 100 years, but in the last 20 years, there has been a huge resurgence of interest.” He's heard of the newly formed Indian Botanical Art Society, and of the courses in Udaipur and elsewhere. “So, this book could serve as a source of inspiration for contemporary artists,” he adds.

Botanical and taxonomical work is going on all the time, he adds. “New species of plants continue to be discovered in India [one of the world's 17 megadiverse countries] because a lot of the work in the early days was done by British botanists who were here on a short-term basis, without the resources or time to explore the more distant places, like Arunachal Pradesh, which is a hotspot. Even the Western Ghats; there are constantly new species in certain groups, like impatiens and begonia.”

Foot soldiers of Indian flora Noltie has just returned to Delhi via Shillong, where he walked through what remains of the Khasi Hills forests – fragmented now, the sacred groves among the few intact pockets – and found, in one forested patch, a tree fern still

THESE FLOWERS HAVE A BACKSTORY

Scottish botanist Henry Noltie hopes the recovery of India's lost botanical art, now in a book, will inspire contemporary artists



tall enough (about 4 ft.) to suggest the canopy it once lived beneath. The same species appears in drawings from two centuries ago at its full, magnificent height of over seven feet.

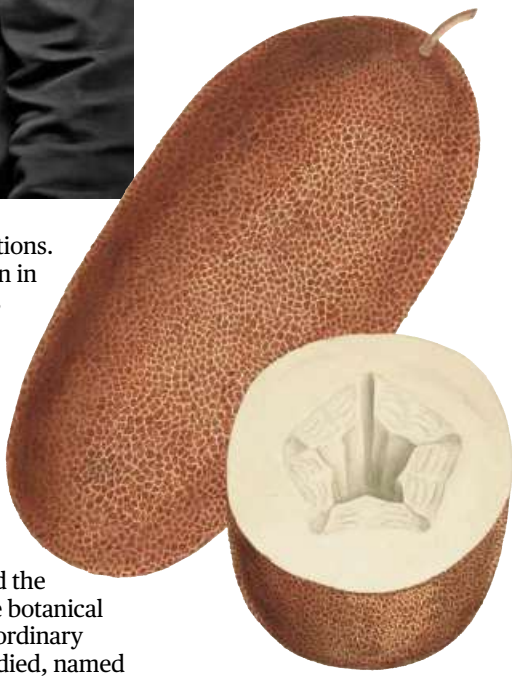
It's the sort of stories and connections that *Flora Indica* is full of: less a coffee table book, more a result of patient historical excavation. Noltie's research explores the work of 20 Indian artists in the service of the East India Company between 1790 and 1850, from 11

of the Kew's collections.

Three stories run in parallel through its pages. There is the institutional history: the Company botanists, the Scottish surgeons, the garden superintendents who commissioned the works. There is the botanical record itself: extraordinary plant life being studied, named

and documented for the first time. And then there is the most elusive thread: the artists. Men such as Vishnuprasad, whose single surviving letter – a charming note welcoming Wallich back to Calcutta after a four-year absence – is one of the only personal documents any of these painters left behind.

Noltie has argued that this school of painting should not be named for its East India Company sponsor but for the Indian artists themselves, the real foot soldiers of the genre. All of this buoyed by illustrations in a mash of styles: Mughal miniature meets Marwar School meets



neoclassicism. Turns out, there is a silver lining to these drawings languishing in dark corners of rooms: the stunning watercolour has stayed naturally preserved.

A life with plants

The instinct to credit the overlooked runs through everything Noltie does. He grew up in Yorkshire and then Dundee, in a family where botany was ambient – his mother, grandmother and great-aunts were all enthusiasts – while empirical study, by way of his scientist father, was a way of life. At Oxford, he wavered briefly between botany and zoology, until a mentor heard of his indecision and looked at him with such undisguised horror that he reconsidered on the spot. “I thought, I can't upset her like that,” he says with a little smile.

Noltie then joined RBGE, where he spent 30 years – beginning in exhibitions, then pivoting to taxonomy, spending 12 years on the flora of Bhutan before turning, after 1999, to the historical and artistic side of RBGE's Indian collections. He retired in 2017, but has barely stopped working since.

Importance of taxonomy

Of course, his primary zone of investigation, the terrain of India, is not like what it was 30 years ago, let alone 200 years ago. On the highway out from Shillong, he remembers with disdain the hillsides being blasted to dust for construction. “I've never seen anything like it,” he says quietly. “Very, very upsetting.”

But not all is lost. He remembers visiting the Rani Baug garden (Jijamata Udyaan) in Mumbai recently and feeling thrilled by the transformation (his last visit was in 2000). In

Kolkata, the Botanic Garden has been similarly revived. “These green lungs are unbelievably important – as a source of solace, inspiration, oxygen, education,” he says.

The *Flora Indica* book, Noltie hopes, will inspire more Indian botanists and artists to engage with the wonders growing in their own backyard. The exhibition, meanwhile, will follow its book to India in facsimile form – to Hyderabad, Mumbai, Kolkata, Bengaluru – the drawings printed at high resolution and framed locally. The art would come home, in its way.

I ask, finally, about the purpose of taxonomy in the 21st century, with its collapsing forests and accelerating extinctions. “Plants are the basis of all biodiversity,” he says. “Having accurate names for plants is fundamental to any conservation or climate change monitoring work.” The number of students choosing to study taxonomy is not what it might be, he adds, but that inexplicable rise in interest in botanical drawing and art is heartening, because the knowledge risks dying with the people who hold it. “It's vitally important that this work continues,” he concludes.

The Mumbai-based independent journalist writes on culture, lifestyle and technology.



Scan the QR code for a peek inside the book, on magazine.thehindu.com

Anisha Menezes

Every spring, rhododendrons paint the Himalayas and parts of the Northeast in vibrant reds, whites, purples and pinks. For writer and poet Sumana Roy, the elusive flower is special. As she writes in ‘Wild Encounters: Searching for Rhododendrons’, her essay in the new book *Paper Gardens: The Lives of Botanical Illustrations in India*, while colonisers were drawn to the flowers for their sensual beauty, “the local will bite and chew the arrogance of the flowers”.

Roy remembers her favourite rhododendron chutney, and even offers a recipe: “Crushing about five or six fresh red rhododendrons into a paste with a clove of garlic, a tomato, and its sweet-sour balance refined by the addition of molasses and dried mango powder. As I look at [British botanist Joseph Dalton] Hooker's *The Rhododendrons of Sikkim-Himalaya*, this is what I miss – the flower inside my mouth.”

The 1849 book listed 33 species, but Roy says lived experience imbues the flowers with far more colour than is possible in the pages of a book.

Colonial expansion and artistic labour

Hooker's rhododendron lithographs, meanwhile, feature in *Paper Gardens: Art, Botany and Empire*, the companion exhibition with over



A book and exhibition at MAP traces the artistic labour and colonial histories behind botanical illustrations from India

Rhododendron and the empire

120 works curated by Impart (formerly MAP Academy) at Bengaluru's Museum of Art & Photography. The show has botanical artwork sourced from the collections of the U.K.'s Linnean Society and Wellcome Collection, and the U.S.'s Oak Spring Garden and the Missouri Botanical Garden – illustrating a time when, “between the 18th and 19th centuries, the Indian subcontinent was a site of

intense scientific activity”, says Shrey Maurya, research director of Impart and curator of the show. “The exhibition emerged from a desire to bring these complex histories of botany, colonial expansion, artistic labour, and the global circulation of plant knowledge to the public.”

It is also an ode to Indian artists whose contribution to botanical taxonomy has been long ignored. “Around 27 works carry attributions to

named artists, including Vishnuprasad, Gorachand, Govindoo, and K. Cheluviah Raju,” says Maurya. “There are also drawings and lithographs made by Indian artists for the *Annals of the Royal Botanic Garden, Calcutta*.”

The book includes essays by experts such as American art historian Holly Shaffer and Scottish botanist Henry Noltie. It has “over a hundred images, and it traces encounters between plants, artists, and institutions – reanimating the networks of labour and imagination that have built our understanding of the natural world”, states Maurya.

The freelance writer is based in Chennai.



(Clockwise from left) Rhododendron; mangosteen; Himalayan honeysuckle; and writer Sumana Roy. (COURTESY MAP)

Stories from Yale

Simultaneously, in the U.S., the exhibition *Painters, Ports, and Profits: Artists and the East India Company, 1750-1850* further expands the story. It showcases Indian, British and Chinese artists whose works were commissioned by the East India Company to support its commercial and imperial goals. The exhibition, of over 100 objects, is mostly drawn from the Yale Center for British Art's collection of works from Asia, including opaque watercolours, large oil portraits, architectural drafts and a spectacular 37-foot-long scroll, titled *Lucknow from the Gomti*. There are scenographies, botanical specimens and fauna too, such as a detailed drawing of a rhinoceros by Gangaram Chintaman Navgire Tambat, from the Maratha Peshwa's menagerie in Pune (1790). *Painters, Ports, and Profits: Artists and the East India Company, 1750-1850* is on till June 21.

Scan the QR code for a walkthrough of *Paper Gardens*, on magazine.thehindu.com